Conversational History of AI & Law (Decade-by-Decade)

The 1950s: The Turing Test

Week 1

- **Memory Hook: *The Fake Human*.**
- **The Tech: Alan Turing created the "Imitation Game" to see if a computer could type messages and successfully trick a human into thinking it was alive.**
- **The Law (Deception): If a machine fakes being human, do people have a fundamental legal right to know they are talking to a robot?**

The 1960s: ELIZA

Week 2

- **Memory Hook: *The Robot Therapist*.**
- **The Tech: The first chatbot, ELIZA, didn't have a brain—it just used simple "IF/THEN" rules to flip a user's statement into a question.**
- **The Law (Privacy): People formed emotional bonds with the bot and shared deep secrets, sparking the very first debates about software manipulating human emotions and data privacy.**

The 1970s: The AI Winter

Week 3

- **Memory Hook: *The Broken Promise*.**
- **The Tech: Computers were too slow to make real AI, progress completely froze, and the government pulled all funding.**
- **The Law (False Advertising): It was the first time lawmakers realized the tech industry was over-hyping a product that simply couldn't deliver, creating a legacy of regulatory skepticism.**

The 1980s: Expert Systems

Week 4

- **Memory Hook: *The Giant Rulebook*.**

- **The Tech: AI bounced back as "Expert Systems"—software that just followed thousands of hand-written rules for niche corporate jobs, like approving bank loans.**
- **The Law (Software Liability): If a hospital uses an Expert System and the AI's "rules" give a patient the wrong diagnosis, who gets sued—the doctor or the programmer?**

The 1990s: Statistics & The Web

Week 5

- **Memory Hook: *Counting Words*.**
- **The Tech: Programmers stopped writing rules and started using statistics to guess the next word; the new World Wide Web gave them the text to learn from.**
- **The Law (Digital Trespassing): Tech companies built bots to aggressively scrape early websites for data, triggering the first lawsuits over violating terms of service.**

The 2000s: Big Data

Week 6

- **Memory Hook: *The Data Hoover*.**
- **The Tech: As Google and social media exploded, algorithms like spam filters and news feeds got smarter by quietly tracking massive amounts of user behavior.**
- **The Law (Data Ownership): Because AI was secretly hoovering up user data to train itself, lawmakers had to invent modern digital privacy rights.**

The 2010s: Neural Networks & Bias

Week 7

- **Memory Hook: *Copying Our Flaws*.**
- **The Tech: AI learned "word math" (grouping concepts together) by reading millions of historical human documents.**
- **The Law (Algorithmic Bias): Because the AI learned from our history, it perfectly copied our prejudices—crashing AI straight into civil rights and anti-discrimination laws (like fair hiring/housing).**

2017–2020: The Transformer (GPT-3)

Week 8

- **Memory Hook: *Reading the Whole Internet*.**
- **The Tech: Google invented a way for AI to read entire sentences at once instead of word-by-word, allowing massive models to digest the whole internet.**
- **The Law (Copyright): This triggered the biggest legal battle in AI today—is it "Fair Use" to train a billion-dollar model on copyrighted books for free?**

2021–2023: ChatGPT & Alignment

Week 9

- **Memory Hook: *Teaching Manners*.**
- **The Tech: Raw AI was unpredictable, so humans were hired to give "thumbs up or down" to its answers, teaching it to be a polite, helpful conversationalist.**
- **The Law (Platform Liability): If this newly polite chatbot confidently tells someone how to build a bomb or gives terrible legal advice, is the tech company legally responsible?**

2024–2026: Agents & Action

Week 10

- **Memory Hook: *AI Takes the Wheel*.**
- **The Tech: AI no longer just talks—it acts. "Agents" can autonomously browse the web, book flights, manage schedules, and hit "buy."**
- **The Law (Agency Law): If your personal AI assistant accidentally signs a bad contract or buys illegal goods on your behalf, are you legally forced to take the blame for what your bot did?**